

A Good Wife *Goes to Club*

It started with a night out with girlfriends



JJ Vale

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The bass pounded through my chest like a second heartbeat, foreign and insistent. I smoothed the hem of my silk blouse, a Zimmermann, a birthday gift from Gerald, and watched my friends throw their heads back in laughter. Their voices disappeared into the club's velvet darkness, swallowed by music I didn't recognize.

I didn't belong there, not in a place where the lights painted everyone in shades of sin and the cocktails came in colors that didn't exist in nature. But it was Megan's thirtieth, and the girls had insisted. Gerald kissed my forehead before his red-eye to Singapore. He murmured *have fun, sweetheart* against my skin, and so here I was.

I took a careful sip of my French 75 and felt the champagne bubbles tickle my nose. Around me, Megan and Courtney and the others had already shed the careful composure they wore to brunches and lunches.

I sat with my ankles crossed beneath the table, my La Perla pressed like a secret against my skin. I watched it all unfold like a nature documentary about creatures I'd only read about. This was their world, not mine. I had been raised on soft music and hard rules, on cotillion dances and Sunday dinners where everyone used the correct fork. My mother had taught me to sit with my knees together. My father had taught me to expect doors held open and chairs pulled out.

Nothing in my twenty-seven years had prepared me for a place like this.

"Oh my God," Courtney suddenly shrieked, loud enough to cut through the music. "Is that *Trey*? Trey! Over here!"

I followed her frantic waving toward the bar, where a man had half-turned at the sound of his name. Even in the shifting light, I could see he was tall. He had a kind of stillness about him that made the chaos around him seem like weather he could ignore.

"That's my brother's friend," Courtney explained to the table. She was already gesturing him over with both hands. "He's *so* fun. You're going to love him."

He moved through the crowd like he owned the place. Bodies parted for him without his asking. When he reached our table, I understood why Courtney had practically vibrated out of her seat. He was striking. His face was the kind that made you forget your manners and stare. His skin glowed the color of warm caramel, and his eyes were a startling hazel against the darkness of his lashes. Stubble shadowed his jaw in a way that looked designed, no lazy. He wore a simple black shirt with the sleeves buttoned, and when he smiled at Courtney, I noticed the slight gap between his front teeth. That small imperfection somehow made everything else about him more perfect.

"Ladies," he said, and his voice rumbled low enough that we all leaned in to hear it over the music. "Happy birthday to the guest of honor."

Megan giggled and I watched her transform into someone I barely recognized. This was what happened here, I realized. This place worked on people like a spell. It loosened them. It unlaced the tight ribbons of propriety that held us all in shape during daylight hours.

Courtney made breathless introductions around the table. She gestured to each of us with her cocktail sloshing dangerously in her other hand. I learned that Trey worked in private equity and that he had gone to Duke with Courtney's older brother Marcus. I learned that he had just returned from three weeks in Morocco, which explained the deeper bronze of his skin and the leather bracelet wrapped twice around his wrist.

His eyes moved around the table as Courtney named us. Sofia. Melissa. Megan. When she reached me, those hazel eyes settled on my face and stayed there a beat too long.

"Halle," Courtney said. "She's the quiet one. We keep trying to corrupt her."

"That so," Trey said. It wasn't a question.

I felt the heat rise to my cheeks and hated myself for it. I was twenty-seven years old. I had a master's degree in art history. I had traveled to fourteen countries and could make conversation with anyone my mother seated me beside at her dinner parties. But something about the way this man looked at me made me feel like I was fumbling through my first dance at the country club.

"Dance with us," Courtney demanded. She was already pulling at his arm. "Trey, you *have* to. It's Megan's birthday."

"Can't argue with birthday rules," he said and he smirked a devastating smirk that we all felt rush through us. He let himself be tugged toward the dance floor with an easy grace that suggested he'd done this many times before.

Megan followed him. Then Sofia rose from her seat. Then even quiet little Melissa abandoned her post, though she had spent the first hour texting her husband under the table. One by one, they migrated toward the pulsing lights and their bodies found rhythms that mine had never learned.

"Halle, come *on*," Courtney called back. She had turned to wave me forward.

I shook my head and lifted my drink as an excuse. "I'm fine here. Go ahead."

Trey's eyes found mine through the crowd. He raised one eyebrow in something that looked like a question. Or maybe a challenge.

I looked down at my glass. The ice had melted and diluted my drink to something pale and watery. I stirred it with the little black straw and listened to the ice clink against the sides.

When I looked up again, my friends had absorbed him into their circle. They danced around him like he was a maypole and they were celebrating some ancient pagan rite. Courtney threw her arms up and swayed with theatrical abandon. Megan pressed closer than a married woman should. Sofia had donned her shoes and lost her inhibitions somewhere in the exchange.

He was good, I could see that much from my safe distance. He didn't dance like the other men in the club, all grinding desperation and wandering hands. He moved with control. He moved with intention. He let the women come to him, and somehow that restraint made him magnetic. He danced with each of them in turn, his hands respectful but present, his body close but not claiming.

I finished my drink and set the empty glass on the middle of the table. The club had grown warmer, or maybe that was just me. I pressed my cool fingers to my cheeks and felt the heat beneath my skin.

The song changed seamlessly to something slower now, though still heavy with bass. I watched the bodies on the dance floor rearrange themselves to match the new rhythm. Couples formed and reformed like cells dividing under a microscope.

I should have been tired and I should have been checking my phone, calculating when I could reasonably suggest we call it a night. But something had changed in the air around me. Something had changed in the quality of the darkness, too. I felt awake in some new way.

Trey broke away from the group and he said something to Courtney that made her laugh and push at his shoulder. Then he was walking toward me, and then he was sliding into the booth across from me., and then he was there, close enough that I could smell his scent. It was something woodsy and warm, a hint of smoke.

"You don't dance," he said.

"I dance," I said. "Just not like that."

He smiled. The gap between his teeth appeared. "Like what, then?"

I thought about the waltz lessons my mother had made me take. I thought about the careful box steps I'd learned for my wedding, Gerald's hand steady on my waist. "Slower," I finally said. "More structured."

"Ah." He nodded like I'd revealed something significant. "You like rules."

"I like knowing what comes next."

He leaned back against the booth and studied me. His eyes moved over my face in a way that felt almost physical, like fingertips tracing my features. I resisted the urge to look away.

"What's your name again?" he asked.

"Halle."

"Halle," he repeated, and the word sounded different in his mouth. Richer, somehow. More substantial. "That's pretty."

"Thank you," I said. The words came out smaller than I wanted.

He flagged down a passing waitress and ordered a whiskey neat. He didn't ask what I wanted, but when the drink arrived, he slid it across the table toward me instead. I looked at the amber liquid, then back at him.

"You looked like you needed something stronger," he said. "The champagne wasn't doing its job."

"What job is that?"

"Helping you relax." He tilted his head and considered me. "You're look wound pretty tight, Halle."

I should have said something cutting and clever and excused myself to find my friends. Instead, I picked up the whiskey and took a sip. It burned going down, but it was a clean burn. Honest. I took another sip.

"There you go," he said, and his smile changed into something softer. "That's better."

Out on the dance floor, Courtney had found a new partner, Megan was taking selfies with Sofia, and they had already forgotten about Trey, absorbed back into their own orbits. No one was watching us. No one would notice if I stayed here talking to this stranger for another five minutes. Or ten.

"So tell me something about yourself," he said. "Something real," he smiled widely.

"What do you mean, real?"

"I mean something you don't tell people at cocktail parties." He leaned forward, and the distance between us shrank. "Tell me something that matters to you."

I thought about the question and I turned it over in my mind like a stone you found on a beach. No one had asked me something like that. Gerald asked me about my day. My mother asked me about my plans. My friends asked me about my opinions on restaurants and vacation destinations and which shade of white I was considering for the living room.

"I used to paint," I finally said. "When I was younger. I was actually quite good."

"What happened?"

"I grew up." I shrugged like it didn't matter. "I got practical. My parents wanted me to have a more stable path, and art history seemed like a reasonable compromise. I could still be around beautiful things without the risk of trying to create them myself."

"That's sad," he said. He didn't say it with pity. He said it like he was simply stating a fact.

"I suppose it could be."

The music shifted. The tempo dropped into something slow and syrupy, all minor chords and longing. A few couples on the dance floor pulled closer together. Others drifted back to their tables, ready for a break.

"Dance with me," Trey said.

"I told you. I don't dance like that."

"Then dance with me the way you do dance." He stood and extended his hand across the table. His palm faced upward, open and waiting. "Just one song. Then I'll leave you alone."

My friends all came back and filled in around the table. I looked at Trey's hand. His fingers were long and elegant. A thin scar ran across his knuckles, white against the brown of his skin. I wondered how he'd gotten it. I wondered what other marks his body carried beneath that simple black shirt.

I put my hand in his.

His fingers closed around mine, and something sparked. Not static electricity, though it felt similar. Something that traveled up my arm and spread through my chest like ink dropped in water. I drew a sharp breath, and I saw his eyes flicker. He felt it too.

He led me to the edge of the dance floor, away from the main crowd and away from my friends. The music wrapped around us like a warm fog. He turned to face me and placed one hand on my waist. His touch was light but certain. He knew exactly what he was doing.

I rested my left hand on his shoulder and felt the muscle shift beneath his shirt. He took my right hand in his and held it at chest height, and we began to move.

He was right. This was different. This was nothing like the grinding chaos happening elsewhere on the floor. This was structure. This was the waltz boxes I knew, adapted to music that had never been meant for such formality. He guided me with subtle pressure, and I followed without thinking. My body understood what to do even when my mind was spinning.

"See?" he murmured. His mouth was close to my ear. "You do dance."

I couldn't answer. Something was happening to me, something was loosening in my chest, like a fist that had been clenched for so long. The heat of his hand on my waist burned through the thin silk of my blouse. His thumb traced a small circle against my hip, and I shivered despite the warmth.

We moved together like we had practiced this a thousand times before. His body anticipated mine. My body responded to his. There was no hesitation, no awkward negotiation of space. We simply fit.

"Relax your shoulders," he said softly. "You're still holding that tension."

I let out a breath I hadn't realized I was holding. My shoulders dropped. My spine softened. I let myself lean into him, and he accepted my weight without stumbling.

The song continued, and we continued with it. The club faded around us. The strobing lights became distant stars. The press of other bodies disappeared until it was only us, turning slowly in our own private universe.

His hand moved higher on my back. His fingers spread across my spine, and I arched into his touch without meaning to. A sound escaped my throat, something between a sigh and a gasp, and I felt his breath catch in response.

"Halle." His voice had dropped into something rough. "Look at me."

I tilted my head back and met his eyes. The hazel had darkened into something closer to gold. I could see myself reflected in his pupils, small and strange and nothing like the woman I saw in my bathroom mirror each morning.

"There you are," he said.

And I understood what he meant. Because I could feel it too, I could feel myself surfacing from somewhere deep. This man I'd known for less than an hour had found a door in me that I didn't know existed. And he had opened it and light was flooding through.

The song ended. Another began. We kept dancing.

His forehead dropped to rest against mine. Our noses almost touched. I could feel his breath on my lips, warm and slightly sweet from whatever he'd been drinking before he came to our table. If I tilted my chin up just a fraction of an inch, our mouths would meet.

So I didn't tilt my chin. But I didn't pull away either.

"What are you doing to me?" I whispered.

"I'm just dancing with you."

But we both knew that was a lie. Something was happening between us, something that had nothing to do with music or movement or the alcohol softening the edges of the night. There was a current running between our bodies, a frequency only we could hear. I felt it in my teeth. I felt it in the small bones of my inner ear. I felt it pooling low in my belly like honey warmed over a flame.

"I should go back to my friends," I said.

"You probably should."

Neither of us moved.

His thumb traced another circle on my back, lower this time. It dipped just below the line of my waist, just above the curve of my hip. Innocent enough, that touch. Invisible to anyone watching. But I felt it everywhere.

"One more song?" he said.

"One more."

We danced.

The second song bled into a third, and I lost count after that. Time had become unreliable. The club existed outside of clocks and schedules. There was only the music and the heat and the pressure of his hand against my back.

At some point, Courtney danced past us with a stranger's arms wrapped around her waist. She caught my eye and grinned. She mouthed something that looked like *finally* and disappeared back into the crowd. I should have stepped away from Trey and returned to the safety of our table. Instead, I let him pull me closer.

His chest pressed against mine now. I could feel his heartbeat through the thin fabric that separated us. It matched mine, or maybe mine had adjusted to match his. We had synchronized without trying, two instruments tuning to the same pitch.

"Your friends are watching you," he murmured into my hair.

"I know."

"Does that bother you?"

Three hours ago, the answer would have been yes. Three hours ago, I had been a different woman. I had been Gerald's wife, my parents' daughter, the quiet one who never knew corruption. Now I was someone who danced with strangers in dark clubs and didn't want to stop.

"No," I said. "It doesn't bother me one bit," I lied.

He made a low sound in his throat. Approval, maybe. Or satisfaction. His hand slid into the curve of my lower back, and I let my head rest against his shoulder. I could smell his cologne more clearly now, mixed with something warmer. His skin. His sweat. The essential scent of him that no bottle could replicate.

The music shifted into something faster, and the spell threatened to break. Other bodies pressed closer. The temperature rose. Trey guided me toward the edge of the floor, away from the crush, and we found ourselves in a dim corner near the exit.

He didn't let go of my hand.

"I should find my friends," I said. The words felt rehearsed, like lines from a play I'd stopped believing in.

"Probably," he agreed.

But we stood there, fingers intertwined. The bass vibrated through the wall behind me. I could feel it in my spine, in my ribs, in all the hollow places of my body.

Trey reached into his pocket with his free hand and he pulled out a slim black card, no bigger than a business card but heavier. More substantial. He pressed it into my palm, and I felt the raised lettering against my skin.

"What's this?"

He leaned in close. His lips brushed the shell of my ear, and I stopped breathing.

"If you enjoyed tonight," he said, "give me a call sometime."

His breath was warm against my neck. I could feel the shape of each word as it left his mouth.

"There are better clubs than this one," he continued. "More interesting places. Places where you don't have to sit at a table watching everyone else have fun."

I tried to form a response, but my throat had closed around the words. My fingers tightened on the card.

"No pressure," he added. He pulled back just enough to meet my eyes. That half-smile played at the corner of his mouth. "Just an invitation."

"To what?"

"To whatever you want it to be." He released my hand and stepped back. The absence of his touch felt like a sudden change in altitude.

He was already moving away, already folding back into the crowd. I watched him stop at the bar and order a drink and I watched him exchange words with a man. He didn't look back at me, but I knew that he knew I was still watching him.

I looked down at the card in my hand. It was matte black, almost invisible in the dim light. I tilted it toward a passing beam from the dance floor and saw the numbers. Nothing else. No name. No address. No explanation. Just ten digits embossed in silver.

I should have left it on the nearest table and walked away. I should have gone to find Courtney and Megan and told them I was ready to go home.

Instead, I slipped the card into my clutch. I felt the soft click of the clasp closing over it. I pressed my hand against the outside of the bag and felt the small rectangular shape through the leather.

It was just a phone number. It didn't mean anything. It didn't commit me to anything. I could throw it away tomorrow when I was sober and sensible

and back inside my regular life.

But I didn't throw it away.

I walked back to our table on legs that felt loosened. I slid into the booth and picked up someone's abandoned water glass and I drank the whole thing without stopping.

Megan appeared beside me, flushed and breathless. Her hair had escaped its careful arrangement and hung in damp strands around her face.

"Where did you disappear to?" she demanded. "One minute you were dancing with that gorgeous man, and the next you were gone."

"I'm right here," I said.

"And? Tell me everything. What's his deal?"

I thought about the card in my clutch. I thought about the weight of it, the way it seemed to pulse against my hip like a second heartbeat. I thought about his voice in my ear, warm and low and full of promises I didn't understand.

"Nothing happened," I said. "We just danced."

Megan looked disappointed. She launched into a story about her own adventures on the dance floor, something about a finance bro who had tried to buy her a bottle of champagne. I nodded in the right places. I laughed when she laughed. I played the part of attentive friend while my mind circled back to those ten silver digits.

The rest of the night passed in a blur. We danced more. We drank more. Courtney fell asleep in the Uber home, and Sofia took a dozen photos that she swore she would never post. I sat by the window and watched the city lights streak past like falling stars.

When I got home, the apartment was dark and quiet. Gerald wouldn't be back until Thursday. I had three days alone with nothing but my thoughts and the card burning a hole in my clutch.

I stood in the bathroom and removed my makeup with careful strokes. I looked at my reflection and tried to find the woman who had danced with a stranger in a dark club. She was there, somewhere behind my eyes. I could see traces of her in the flush that still stained my cheeks.

I brushed my teeth and washed my face. I changed into the silk pajamas Gerald had bought me for our anniversary and climbed into our king-sized bed.

The card sat on my nightstand. I had taken it out of my clutch without really deciding to and set it beside my phone and my water glass and the

framed photo of Gerald and me on our wedding day.

I turned off the lamp. The room went dark. I could still feel the ghost of Trey's hand on my back, his breath on my neck, his voice curling through my ear like smoke.

If you enjoyed tonight, give me a call sometime.

I closed my eyes and tried to sleep.

I lay in the darkness and stared at the ceiling while my body hummed with something. Every time I closed my eyes, I felt his hand on my waist and his breath on my neck. I felt the way our bodies had moved together like they had known each other for years instead of minutes.

I rolled onto my side and looked at the card on my nightstand. The silver numbers caught the faint light from the street outside. They seemed to glow in the darkness, patient and waiting.

This was ridiculous. I was a married woman. I had a beautiful apartment and a successful husband and a life that anyone would envy. I had everything I was supposed to want. I had checked every box on the list my mother had written for me before I was old enough to hold a pencil.

I didn't need to call strange men from nightclubs. I didn't need better clubs or more interesting places. I didn't need whatever Trey was offering.

But I could still feel the heat of his palm through my blouse. I could still smell his cologne on my skin, faint but unmistakable. I had showered, but still it lingered, like he had marked me somehow, like he had left something behind that soap and water couldn't touch.

I pressed my thighs together and felt a pulse of warmth between them. My body was responding to memories, to sensations that had ended hours ago. I was lying in the bed I shared with my husband, and I was wet for another man.

The realization should have horrified me. Instead, it sent another wave of heat through my belly.

I reached for my phone. The screen glowed to life, and I saw three messages from Gerald. Photos of his hotel room. A blurry shot of the Singapore skyline at night. A string of heart emojis followed by *Sweet dreams, beautiful.*

I typed back *Miss you* and set the phone face down on the mattress.

The card was still there. Still waiting. I picked it up and held it in the darkness. The edges were sharp against my fingertips. I traced the embossed numbers and felt each one rise beneath my touch.

Of course I wouldn't call. I was just curious. I was just processing an unusual evening. Tomorrow I would wake up and laugh at myself. Tomorrow I would tuck the card into a drawer and forget about it. Tomorrow I would be myself again.

But tomorrow was still hours away, and tonight I felt like someone else entirely.

I set the card back on the nightstand and slid my hand beneath the covers. My silk pajamas whispered against my skin as I moved. I told myself I was just going to sleep. I told myself my hand trailing down my stomach meant nothing.

My fingers found the waistband of my shorts. They slipped beneath the elastic and traveled lower. I was wet and swollen, my body already prepared for something my mind hadn't agreed to. When I touched myself, I gasped into the empty room.

I thought about Gerald. I tried to picture his face, his hands, the familiar weight of him above me. But the image wouldn't hold. It kept dissolving, reforming into someone taller. Someone with caramel skin and hazel eyes and a gap between his teeth.

I circled my fingers and felt the pressure build. My hips lifted off the mattress. The sheets tangled around my legs as I moved against my own hand. I was breathing harder now, my chest rising and falling beneath the thin silk.

In my mind, Trey was still dancing with me. But we weren't in the club anymore. We were somewhere private, somewhere dark and warm. His hand wasn't on my waist. It was lower, slipping beneath fabric, finding the places I was touching now.

I imagined his voice in my ear. That low rumble, rough with want. I imagined him telling me to relax, to let go, to stop holding so tight to the woman I was supposed to be.

My back arched. My free hand curled in the sheets. I turned my face into the pillow to muffle the sounds escaping my throat.

When I came, it crashed through me like a wave I didn't see approaching. My whole body shuddered. Stars burst behind my closed eyelids. I rode it out with Trey's name on my lips, silent but unmistakable.

Afterward, I lay there panting in the darkness. My hand was still between my legs, still feeling the aftershocks pulse against my fingertips. Sweat cooled on my skin. My heart hammered against my ribs.

I had never done that before. I had never thought about anyone except Gerald when I touched myself. I had never even been tempted. Our intimacy was gentle and predictable, and I had always told myself that was enough. I had told myself I wasn't the kind of woman who needed more.

But my body was telling me something different now. My body was speaking a language I had never learned, and it was saying that I had been starving without knowing I was hungry.

I withdrew my hand and wiped it on the sheets. I would have to wash them tomorrow. I would have to erase the evidence of whatever this was.

I picked up the card again. The numbers had memorized themselves somehow. I could see them when I closed my eyes, burned into the darkness like a brand.

I couldn't call. I was married. I was faithful. I was good.

But I didn't put the card in a drawer. I set it back on the nightstand, propped against the lamp where I could see it. And when I finally fell asleep, I dreamed of dancing in a club that went on forever, with a man whose hands knew exactly where to touch me.

I woke to sunlight streaming through the curtains I had forgotten to close. My body felt heavy and unfamiliar, like I had borrowed it from someone else overnight. The sheets were tangled around my legs, evidence of restless sleep.

The card was the first thing I saw when I opened my eyes.

I sat up and reached for my phone. It was nearly eleven. I never slept that late, was a morning person. I did yoga at seven and ate egg-white omelets at eight. I had routines. I had structure. I had a life that ran on a schedule as precise as a Swiss watch.

Today, all of that felt like it belonged to someone else.

I had three new messages from Gerald. A photo of his breakfast. A complaint about jetlag. A question about whether I had remembered to water the orchids.

I typed back a response about the orchids and I added a heart emoji. I set the phone aside and looked at the card.

In the daylight, it seemed less magical. It was just a rectangle of black cardstock with some numbers printed on it. It could have been anything. A loyalty card for a coffee shop. A business card from a financial advisor. It didn't have to mean what I had decided it meant in the darkness.

I picked it up and carried it into the bathroom. I stood over the toilet and held it above the water. One flick of my wrist, and it would be gone. One moment of strength, and I would be the woman I was supposed to be again.

I stood there for a long time.

Then I walked back to the bedroom and tucked the card into the top drawer of my vanity, beneath my La Perla bras and my silk underwear and all the other secret things I wore under my respectable clothes.

I would decide later. I would think about it more clearly when I was dressed and fed and back inside my regular life. I would be sensible about this. I would be careful.

But when I closed the drawer, my hand lingered on the handle. And when I looked at myself in the mirror, I saw a woman I still didn't entirely recognize.

She was flushed. She was bright-eyed. She was holding a secret that made her whole body hum with electricity.

She looked alive.

I spent the day trying to be normal. I watered the orchids. I went to my Pilates class and held planks until my arms shook. I met my mother for lunch at the club and listened to her talk about the Michaelson's divorce and the new landscaping at the Whitfields' estate. I nodded in all the right places. I cut my salad into small pieces and chewed each bite thoroughly.

But beneath the table, my leg bounced with a restless energy I couldn't contain. And every time my phone buzzed, my heart lurched into my throat before I remembered that he didn't have my number. Only I had his.

"You seem distracted, darling," my mother said over her third glass of Sancerre. "Is everything alright with Gerald?"

"Everything's fine," I said. "He's just traveling. You know how it is."

"I do know how it is." She reached across the table and patted my hand. "Your father was the same way when we were young. Always on a plane somewhere. But it gets easier. You learn to fill the time."

I thought about the ways I had filled my time last night. I felt heat climb up my neck and hoped she would mistake it for the warmth of the restaurant.

"I'm fine, Mother. Really."

She studied me for a moment longer, then returned to her monologue about the Michaelsons. I excused myself to the bathroom and stood in front of the mirror, gripping the edges of the marble sink.

My reflection looked the same as always. Subtle makeup. Hair blown out in soft waves. Pearl earrings that Gerald had given me on our first anniversary. Everything about me screamed taste and restraint and careful cultivation.

But my eyes told a different story. They were too bright. Too hungry. They belonged to a woman who was keeping a secret, and the secret was eating her alive.

I splashed cold water on my wrists and returned to the table. I survived the rest of lunch. I kissed my mother goodbye in the parking lot and drove home with the windows down, letting the wind whip my careful hair into chaos.

The apartment was too quiet when I returned. I walked through the rooms like a stranger, noticing things I had stopped seeing years ago. The wedding photos on the mantel. The coordinated throw pillows Gerald's mother had picked out. The abstract art we had bought together in Paris, chosen because it matched the sofa rather than because we loved it.

Everything was beautiful. Everything was tasteful. Everything was exactly what it was supposed to be.

I climbed the stairs to the bedroom. I told myself I was going to take a bath. I told myself I was going to read the novel I had started three weeks ago and never finished.

Instead, I walked straight to my vanity. I opened the top drawer. I pushed aside silk and lace until my fingers found the sharp edges of the card.

I sat down on the bed and looked at it. The numbers stared back at me, patient and undemanding. He had said no pressure. He had said no expectations. He had given me a choice, and the choice was mine to make.

I picked up my phone and I typed the numbers into a new message. My thumb hovered over the keyboard, trembling slightly.

What would I even say? *Hi, this is the woman you danced with last night. The married one who couldn't stop shaking when you touched her.*

I deleted the numbers. I set the phone aside. I pressed my palms to my face and took deep breaths until my heartbeat slowed.

This was insane. I didn't do things like this, I had never even thought about doing things like this. Gerald and I had been together since I was twenty-four. He was the only man I had slept with since my brief and

fumbling college experiences. He was the only man I had wanted to sleep with.

Until now.

I stood up and walked to the bathroom. I turned on the shower as hot as it would go and I stripped off my clothes and stepped beneath the spray, letting the water pound against my shoulders until my skin turned pink.

But even the heat couldn't burn away the memory of his hands. Even the steam couldn't cloud the image of his eyes finding mine across the dance floor. He had looked at me like he could see through all my careful layers. He had looked at me like he knew exactly who I was underneath.

My hand drifted down my stomach. The water streamed over my body as I touched myself for the second time in twelve hours. I braced one hand against the tile wall and let the other work between my legs. I was already wet, already swollen, already desperate.

This time, I didn't try to think about Gerald. I let myself sink into the fantasy fully. I imagined Trey in the shower with me, his body pressed against my back. I imagined his hands replacing mine, his fingers sliding through my slickness. I imagined his voice in my ear, telling me how good I felt, how long he had wanted to touch me like this.

I came with a cry that echoed off the tiles. My knees buckled, and I had to catch myself against the wall. The water poured over me as I shuddered through the aftershocks, gasping for breath.

When I finally stepped out of the shower, my legs were unsteady. I wrapped myself in a towel and sat on the edge of the tub. My reflection in the fogged mirror was a blur, a smudge where a woman should be.

I couldn't keep doing this. I couldn't keep touching myself to thoughts of a stranger while my husband sent me photos from across the world. I had to make a choice. I had to either throw the card away or admit what I wanted.

I dried off and put on fresh clothes. Simple things. Cotton underwear instead of silk. Leggings and a soft sweater. The kind of outfit I wore when I was alone and didn't need to be anyone's wife or daughter or friend.

Then I went back to the bedroom and picked up my phone.

I typed the numbers again. I stared at the blinking cursor for a long moment.

This is Halle, I finally wrote. From last night.

I hit send before I could change my mind. The message disappeared into the digital void, and there was no taking it back.

I set the phone face down on the nightstand. I told myself I wouldn't stare at it. I told myself I would go downstairs and make dinner and pretend I hadn't just done what I had done.

But the phone buzzed.

My heart stopped. I counted to ten before I allowed myself to flip it over.

I was hoping you'd reach out, the message said. How are you feeling?

My fingers trembled as I typed back. *I don't know. Strange. Like I'm someone else.*

The reply came immediately. *Maybe you're finally becoming who you were supposed to be.*

I stared at those words. I read them again and again until they stopped making sense, then kept reading until they made a different kind of sense altogether.

What did you mean, I wrote, about better clubs?

The three dots appeared. Disappeared. Appeared again. I watched them pulse like a heartbeat.

There's a place I go sometimes. Very private. Very exclusive. It's not for everyone, but I think you might enjoy it.

What kind of place?

Another pause. Then: *The kind of place where you don't have to pretend to be anyone.*

I pressed my hand to my chest and felt my heart slamming against my ribs. I knew I should stop. I knew I should delete this conversation and block his number and never think about him again.

Instead, I wrote: *Tell me more.*

The three dots pulsed for what felt like hours. I sat on the edge of my bed, phone clutched in both hands, watching those tiny bubbles rise and fall like something breathing beneath the surface.

Finally, his response arrived.

It's easier to show than to tell. Are you free Thursday night?

Thursday. The day Gerald was supposed to return. But his flight didn't land until nearly midnight, and I always stayed home when he traveled. I always waited like a faithful dog for its master to return.

I might be, I typed. What would we do?

Dinner first. Then we'll see.

My stomach flipped. This was real now. This was a plan, a time, a place. This was no longer a fantasy I could dismiss as the product of too much champagne and a lonely night.

I don't know if I can, I wrote.

You can. The question is whether you will.

I set the phone down and stood up. I paced the length of the bedroom, my bare feet silent on the plush carpet. The late afternoon sun slanted through the windows and painted golden stripes across the bed where Gerald and I slept every night. Where we made love once a week, usually on Saturday mornings, usually in the same position, usually finished within fifteen minutes.

My phone buzzed again.

No pressure, Halle. I meant that. But I felt something last night, and I don't think I was alone in that.

He wasn't wrong about any of it.

I picked up the phone. *I felt it too.*

Then give yourself permission to explore. Just dinner. Just conversation. You can leave whenever you want.

Just dinner. Just conversation. The words were so reasonable. So innocent. They could have described any meal between any two acquaintances. There was nothing in those words that should have made my pulse race and my palms sweat.

But we both knew better. We both knew that dinner was not just dinner. Conversation was not just conversation. The thread between us was already pulling taut, and following it would lead me somewhere I had never been.

Where would we go?

There's a restaurant in the Meatpacking District. Very quiet. Very discreet. The kind of place no one would know you..

Discreet. The word hung in the air like smoke. Discreet meant hidden. Discreet meant secret. Discreet meant doing something that required discretion in the first place.

What's it called?

I'll send you the address Thursday. Wear something that makes you feel beautiful.

I looked at myself in the mirror across the room. The woman staring back at me was flushed, bright-eyed, trembling with something that might

have been fear or might have been excitement. I couldn't tell the difference anymore.

What time?

Eight o'clock. I'll be waiting.

I typed and deleted three different responses. Finally, I settled on the simplest one.

Okay.

The word looked impossibly small on the screen. Four letters that could change everything. Four letters that already had.

I'm looking forward to it, he replied. *Sweet dreams, Halle.*

I set the phone face down on the nightstand and lay back on the bed. The ceiling fan turned lazy circles above me. The apartment was so quiet I could hear my own heartbeat pounding in my ears.

I had just agreed to have dinner with another man. A man who made my skin burn and my thoughts scatter. A man who looked at me like I was a present he couldn't wait to unwrap.

This was so wrong. Everything about this was wrong. I was supposed to be arranging flowers and planning dinner parties and waiting patiently for my husband to come home. I was supposed to be content with my beautiful life and my beautiful apartment and my beautiful, gentle, predictable marriage.

But contentment had never made me feel like this. Contentment had never made my blood sing and my body ache. Contentment was a lukewarm bath, and Trey was a fire I wanted to throw myself into.

I didn't eat dinner that night. I couldn't imagine putting food in my mouth when my stomach was churning with anticipation. Instead, I drank a glass of wine and then another. I wandered through the apartment touching things that belonged to my married life. The crystal vase Gerald's mother had given us. The cashmere throw we had bought in Scotland. The framed photo of our honeymoon in Positano, both of us sunburned and smiling like we had won something.

We had won something, I supposed. We had won the life everyone wanted. We had won the approval of our parents and the envy of our friends. We had won stability and security and a future as predictable as a train running on tracks.

I picked up the photo and looked at my own face. I tried to remember what I had been feeling the moment the shutter clicked. Happy, probably.

Relieved. Grateful to have checked the final box on the list of things a good girl was supposed to do.

But had I ever felt the way I felt last night? Had Gerald ever made my whole body tremble just by putting his hand on my waist? Had I ever gone home from an evening with him and touched myself until I screamed?

I set the photo back on the shelf. The answer was no. I just hadn't known the question until now.

The next two days passed in a fever dream. I went through the motions of my life, but nothing felt real. I had coffee with Sofia and didn't hear a word she said. I attended a charity committee meeting and couldn't remember what cause we were supporting. I spoke to Gerald every night on the phone, and my voice sounded strange in my own ears, like someone had recorded me and was playing it back at the wrong speed.

"You sound tired, sweetheart," Gerald said on Wednesday night. "Are you getting enough sleep?"

"I'm fine," I said. "Just missing you."

The lie came so easily. That was the part that frightened me most. I had never been a good liar. I had never needed to be. But now the false words slipped from my mouth like honey, smooth and sweet and utterly convincing.

"I'll be home tomorrow night," he said. "We can have a quiet weekend. Maybe go to that new restaurant you wanted to try."

"That sounds perfect."

We said goodnight. We said I love you. I hung up the phone and felt nothing but relief that the conversation was over.

I opened my closet and stood in front of the rows of carefully organized clothes. Blouses arranged by color. Dresses sorted by occasion. Shoes lined up like soldiers awaiting inspection. Everything in its place. Everything exactly where it should be.

I reached for a dress I had never worn. I had bought it on a whim six months ago, seduced by the way the fabric draped and the way the neckline plunged. Gerald would have called it too provocative. My mother would have asked who I was trying to impress.

I had hidden it in the back of the closet, tags still attached, waiting for an occasion that would never come.

Until now.

I pulled it out and held it against my body. The silk was the color of midnight, so dark it seemed to absorb the light. The cut was simple but devastating, designed to skim every curve and suggest everything it covered.

I imagined Trey seeing me in this dress. I imagined his eyes traveling down my body, taking in every inch. I imagined his hands following the same path later, peeling the fabric away to find what lay beneath.

I hung the dress on the outside of the closet door, where I would see it first thing in the morning. Then I went to my vanity and opened the top drawer. I selected the lingerie I would wear underneath. Black lace. Sheer panels. The kind of underwear that existed only to be seen, only to be removed.

I knew I was crossing a line. But the line had started to feel imaginary, a boundary drawn in sand that the tide was slowly washing away.

I climbed into bed and closed my eyes. Tomorrow night, I would have dinner with another man. Tomorrow night, I would sit across from him in a quiet restaurant and feel the heat between us build. Tomorrow night, I would find out what happened when I stopped being good.

The thought should have terrified me.

Instead, I smiled into the darkness and fell into the deepest sleep I'd had in years.

Thursday arrived like a held breath finally released. I woke before my alarm, my body already humming with anticipation. The dress hung on the closet door where I had left it, dark and waiting.

I spent the morning in a trance of preparation. I shaved my legs twice to make sure they were perfectly smooth. I applied a mask to my face and let it tighten while I soaked in a bath scented with jasmine and rose. I rubbed lotion into every inch of my skin until I was soft and fragrant and gleaming.

This was what I was good at. This was what I had been trained for. All those years of learning to present myself, to package myself, to make myself beautiful for others to admire. I had never questioned who I was making myself beautiful for. I had assumed it would always be Gerald.

But today, every stroke of the razor was for Trey. Every brush of powder, every sweep of mascara, every careful application of the lipstick I chose, a deep burgundy that made my mouth look swollen and ripe. I was preparing myself like an offering. I was wrapping myself like a gift.

At six o'clock, my phone buzzed.

The address, Trey wrote. I'll be at the bar when you arrive.

I memorized the location. A restaurant I had never heard of, tucked away on a cobblestone street in the Meatpacking District. The kind of place you only knew about if someone told you.

I stepped into the black dress and felt the silk slide over my skin like water. The fabric clung to my breasts and skimmed my waist and fell in a cascade to my mid-thigh. The neckline plunged low enough to reveal the shadow of my cleavage, the lace edge of my bra just visible if I moved a certain way.

I looked at myself in the mirror. I didn't look like Gerald's wife. I didn't look like my mother's daughter. I looked like a woman who knew exactly what she wanted and was going to take it.

The Uber dropped me at the corner at seven fifty-five. I smoothed my dress and walked down the cobblestones in heels that clicked with each step. The restaurant had no sign, just a heavy wooden door with a brass handle worn smooth by countless hands.

I pushed it open and stepped inside.

The room was dim and intimate, all velvet banquettes and candlelight. Soft jazz played from hidden speakers. The air smelled of expensive wine and something deeper, muskier, like secrets kept in dark corners.

And there was Trey.

He sat at the bar in a charcoal suit that made his shoulders look impossibly broad. He was watching the door when I walked in, and his eyes found mine immediately. Something shifted in his expression, something hungry and pleased and utterly focused.

He stood as I approached. His gaze traveled down my body with deliberate slowness, taking in the dress, the heels, the careful architecture of my appearance. When his eyes returned to my face, they were darker than I remembered.

"You came," he said.

"I came."

He reached for my hand and raised it to his lips. The kiss he pressed to my knuckles was soft and warm and lingered a beat too long. I felt it travel up my arm and settle in my chest like a coal catching fire.

"You look incredible," he murmured against my skin. "Even better than I imagined."

So he had been imagining me. The thought made my knees weak.

He guided me to a booth in the back corner, his hand resting on the small of my back. The pressure of his palm burned through the thin silk. I slid onto the velvet seat, and he slid in beside me. Not across from me. Beside me. Close enough that I could feel the heat of his thigh against mine.

We ordered wine. We ordered food. I couldn't tell you what we ate or what we discussed. I was too aware of his body next to mine, the way he leaned in when he spoke, the way his hand found my knee beneath the table and stayed there.

His thumb traced small circles against my skin. Each circle traveled higher. Each circle made my breath come shorter.

"You're trembling," he observed.

"I know."

"Are you nervous?"

"Yes."

His hand slid higher, pushing the hem of my dress up my thigh.
"Nervous means you're alive."

His fingers found the edge of my stockings, the bare skin above. I gasped and gripped the edge of the table.

"Tell me to stop," he said quietly. "And you know I will."

I said nothing. I couldn't speak. I couldn't breathe. I could only sit there while his hand traveled higher, while his fingers brushed against the lace of my underwear and he felt how wet I already was.

"God," he breathed. "You're soaked."

I closed my eyes. His finger traced along the edge of the lace, teasing me, promising.

"Look at me, Halle."

I opened my eyes. His face was inches from mine. His hazel eyes burned into me with an intensity that made my whole body clench.

"I'm going to take you somewhere," he said. "Somewhere private. And I'm going to do things to you. Things that will ruin you for anyone else."

His finger slipped beneath the lace. He found my clit and pressed, just once, just enough to make me whimper.

"Is that what you want?"

I thought about Gerald. I thought about my beautiful apartment and my beautiful life and all the boxes I had checked on my mother's list. I thought about the woman I was supposed to be.

Then I looked into Trey's eyes, and I let her go.

"Yes," I whispered. "That's what I want."

He smiled. That gap between his teeth appeared and disappeared. His finger circled once, twice, drawing another gasp from my throat.

"Then finish your wine," he said. "We have somewhere to be."

He withdrew his hand and lifted his glass like nothing had happened. I sat there shaking, my dress pulled up, my underwear damp, my whole body screaming for more.

I picked up my wine and drained it in one swallow. Whatever came next, there was no going back now.